# Colossians 4:7–18 — Leader / Learner Guide

*Portrait of a Ministry Team · a one-page guide for leaders and learners*

Christ Is All — A Study of Colossians · TheGospelVault.com · @iJohn.316 (Instagram)

## ① Big Idea and Context

**Big idea:** No one can do it all: God uses a team of faithful, varied, and restored people to carry His Word, and each believer must fulfill the ministry received in the Lord, by His grace.

Paul closes with greetings and instructions. Tychicus and Onesimus carry the letter; Jewish and Gentile coworkers send greetings; the Lycus Valley churches are charged to share letters and fulfill their ministries.

- **The helpers:** Tychicus the dependable; Onesimus the restored.
- **The team:** Aristarchus, Mark, Justus (Jewish); Epaphras, Luke, Demas (Gentile).
- **The family:** care, read the letters, fulfill your ministry, rest in grace.

## ② The Team and the Task — Three Anchor Verses

| Verse | What it says | Teaching point |
|---|---|---|
| 4:7–9 | *"Tychicus, our beloved brother … Onesimus, our faithful and beloved brother"* | God uses the dependable and the restored. |
| 4:12 | *"Epaphras … always laboring earnestly for you in his prayers"* | Prayer is a ministry that knows no distance. |
| 4:17 | *"Take heed to the ministry which you have received in the Lord, that you may fulfill it"* | Every believer has a ministry to fulfill. |

**Mark and Demas:** one restored after failure (2 Tim. 4:11), one drifted into loving the world (2 Tim. 4:10).

**Series close:** Christ is all, and in all (3:11); grace be with you (4:18).

## ③ Teaching Flow

**1. The helpers (4:7–9)** — Tychicus's titles and purpose; Onesimus, from runaway to brother.

**2. The front row (4:10–11)** — Aristarchus, Mark, Justus; "an encouragement to me."

**3. The back row (4:12–14)** — Epaphras's prayers, Luke's gift, Demas's weakness.

**4. The family (4:15–16)** — Greet the brethren; Nympha's house church; exchange the letters; Laodicea later.

**5. Fulfill and rest (4:17–18)** — Archippus's charge; Paul's signature, chains, and grace.

## ④ Clarify While Teaching

- **Textual variants:** v.8 NASB95 "that you may know about our circumstances" (NKJV "that he may know your circumstances"); v.15 NASB95 "Nympha … her house" (NKJV "Nymphas … his house").
- **"Barabbas":** means "son of the father"; the "Jesus Barabbas" reading appears in some manuscripts of Matthew 27:16–17.
- **Archippus:** that he served in Epaphras's place is a reasonable suggestion, not stated in the text.
- **Revelation 3:20:** the study reads it as addressed to believers in Laodicea; many also use it evangelistically.
- **Multiplication illustration:** doubling reaches the world's population in roughly 33 steps; avoid exact claims.

## ⑤ Discussion and Close

1. Which person in this portrait do you most identify with right now, and why?
2. What warning does Demas give us, and how does 1 John 2:15–16 help explain it?
3. What ministry have you "received in the Lord" that still needs to be fulfilled?

**Close:** Series review: Christ is preeminent (ch. 1), sufficient (ch. 2), our life (ch. 3), and Lord of every relationship and ministry (chs. 3–4). "Grace be with you."

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